

We sized each other up for a few seconds. Then Sharma spoke: 'I would like to buy some stock off you.'

I immediately realized he knew about my Apollo Tyres trade. No client ever reveals his hand before asking for a quote.

'Which one?' I asked, knowing the answer fully well.

'Come off it, Lala, you know which one, else I would have asked for a quote first,' he said.

'Since you know where I stand, it goes without saying that you already have a price in mind,' I said, trying to sound dignified.

'You are right, let's deal straight. What did you buy it for?' he asked.

I told him the right price, aware that he knew it.

'Okay, I will buy it from you at ten paise below your cost price,' he said.

'That's generous on your part, knowing the situation I am in,' I said, and then wondered if I had given myself away.

'Let me put it this way. Some people would like to see you in trouble, and we would like to deny them that satisfaction. Besides, we are buyers in the stock if the price is reasonable,' Sharma said.

'Who is the "we"?' I asked, just to confirm my conclusion about who could be behind this gift from heaven.

'Too clever by half, aren't you, Lala? I take it that you are sufficiently informed about who I work for,' Sharma said.

'Even if it is unintended generosity, why not go the whole way and buy my position at cost?' I asked.

'So that you realize there is a cost to stupidity. Ten paise is no big deal. But if you are let off the hook clean, you could get into bigger trouble next time,' Sharma said, noting down the deal in his *sauda* pad.

'Am I supposed to be grateful for this act of kindness?' I asked.

'Well, that's up to you,' Sharma said, walking away.

The following day, Owl approached me, saying he was willing to buy back the Apollo Tyres position at three rupees below my selling price.

'We all make mistakes, Lala, but I don't want somebody to be out of a job because of his immaturity,' Owl said, perhaps hoping that I would beg him for a better price.

'That's very magnanimous of you,' I said, and leaning forward, whispered into his ear where he could shove up that offer.

But for AS-PS themselves having made a formidable enemy in my unlikely benefactor, I would have been in serious trouble. The loss of Rs